Reviving the forgotten arts

MADRAS

Just as nature taught man to survive and provide for basic needs such as food, clothing and shelter, it also drew him to its many splendoured treasures putting his creativity to test. Thus flowed a series of artefacts that pleased the aesthetics within man. From them on till today has been a long journey when all things bright and beautiful have acquired a synthetic edge, reflecting the frantic pace of life. Fortunately there is of late a move to go back to where nature is the presiding deity. Thus artisans-forgotten and neglected-have been pulled back into circulation and their works have begun their trek back into many homes.

The Crafts Council of India, is one such organisation that has recognised the importance of reviving the forgotten arts of India and has made it possible for many homes to acquire such artefacts. As part of its constant endeavour to *reintroduce traditional products, and reactivate* abandoned techniques and processes, it is organising an exhibition — "Marumalarchi" or reblossoming at the Crafts Council premises, Cathedral Road from November 11 to 18. The exhibition will feature products of Tamil Nadu — the tie and dye Chungdi saris from Madurai, vegetable yarn dyed saris from Salem, wood carvings from Thamampatti, kalchattis from Salem, rosewood carved reapers and picture frames from Madurai and brass sheet metal works from the Poompuhar Sheet Metal Production Centre, Madurai. Particularly interesting are the soapstone works — lovely lamps specially for Kartikai, jars, dishes, bowls, tumblers, costers, vessels etc. and the wooden combs that are far more hygienic than plastic or the metal ones.

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